



SYRIA

Capital city: Damascus
Area: 71,498 sq miles (185,180 sq km)
Population: 17,800,000
Official language: Arabic
Major religions: Muslim 90%, Christian 10%
Government: One-party dictatorship
Currency: Syrian pound
Adult literacy rate: 83%
Life expectancy: 70 years
People per doctor: 769
Televisions: 70 per 1,000 people

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SYRIA IS AN ANCIENT LAND. Its capital, Damascus, is one of the world's oldest cities. Because of its important position on major trade routes, Syria has been invaded and occupied many times – by the Romans, Arabs, Greeks, and Turks. After World War I, it came under French control, becoming independent in 1941. Since then Syria has been involved in several wars with Israel. Most Syrians are Muslim and speak Arabic. More than half of Syria is desert, but the river floodplains provide fertile land.

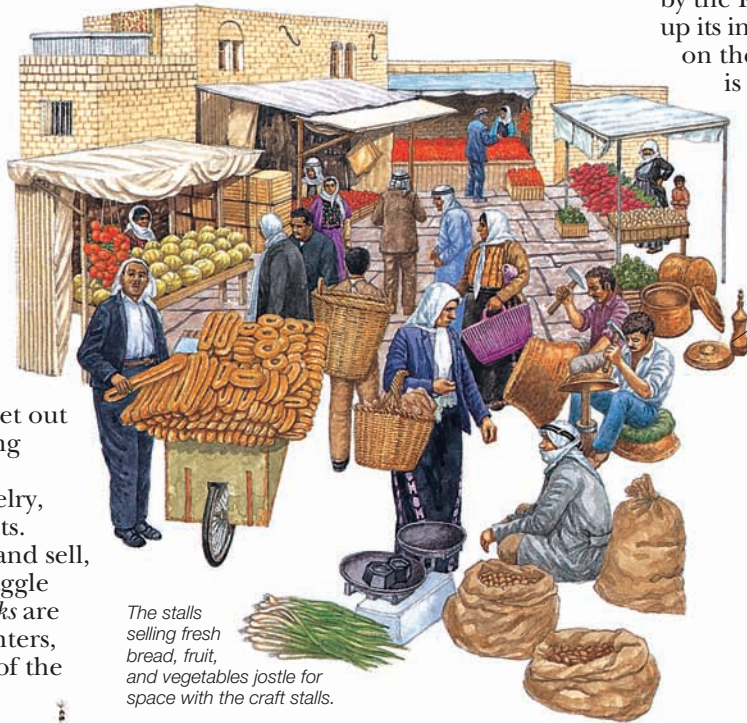


PALMYRA

The rich and varied history of Syria is reflected in the many ancient ruins from past civilizations found scattered throughout the country. In the 3rd century, Palmyra, with its palaces, temples, and theaters, was a flourishing city, but it was destroyed by the Romans for refusing to give up its independence. It lies in an oasis on the edge of the desert, and is one of the best preserved ancient cities in the world.

MARKETS

Markets, or *souks*, are held in villages and towns throughout Syria. The *souks* are lively, bustling places, with market stalls set out on winding alleyways selling anything from spices and vegetables, to carpets, jewelry, basketwork, and coffee pots. People come here to buy and sell, meet their friends, and haggle (bargain) over prices. *Souks* are more than just trading centers, they are a central feature of the Arab way of life.



The stalls selling fresh bread, fruit, and vegetables jostle for space with the craft stalls.

Craftsmen and women are often seen working at their stalls in the souk: beating and engraving copper, carving wood, and weaving baskets.

MUSLIM GROUPS

The majority of Syrians belong to the traditionally powerful Sunni Muslim group. But there are other Muslim sects, such as the Shi'as, Ismailis, and Alawis. The Alawis believe not only in Islam, but in some aspects of Christianity. For example, they celebrate Christmas and Easter. The Alawis were persecuted in the past, but many have now become rich and powerful. President Assad of Syria was an Alawi Muslim.



A minaret (tower) on a Muslim mosque, from which the faithful are called to prayer five times a day

THE EUPHRATES DAM

The Euphrates River flows through the northeast of Syria on its journey from Turkey to Iraq. A gigantic dam has been built across the river to harness the power of the water and produce hydro electricity. Sharing the waters of the Euphrates is a big issue for Turkey, Syria, and Iraq. A huge lake, Lake Assad, was also created by the dam. Water from the lake is used to grow crops.



THE GOLAN HEIGHTS

The mountainous area known as the Golan Heights was seized from Syria by Israel in 1967. It is important to the Israelis because it overlooks the Hula Valley in Israel, offering a good strategic position. It has been a major issue in past peace talks between the two countries, but the renewed Israeli-Palestinian conflict since 2001 has left the issue unresolved.

Find out more

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